The Transmission of the New Testament

The original New Testament Greek text was written in capital letters without spacing. It is known as the **uncials**. The upper and lower cases came only later and that is the **minuscules**. Eventually, copying of the New Testament produced textual variants. It is estimated that over 2500 textual witnesses exist for the New Testament. These texts often do not agree. These texts are grouped into three text types. Texts fall into types owing to nature of how they were copied. As far as we can tell, most or all of the earliest copies were done in what is called a free style. People copied liberally , perhaps correcting what they saw as mistakes ,and even adding comments in the appear to fall Into the third category of strict copies. Strict copies , like their name suggests, have little copying would become more common as time passed. copying freely and then more strictly tended to produce local variations in the text. Each text types preserves certain variants in the text,and as even more time passed.

In contrast to the Old Testament where we have a representative for the whole text, the New Testament is made from many different manuscripts. The Old Testament is therefore rightly referred to as a diplomatic text and the New Testament as the eclectic text.

WHAT IS THE NEW TESTAMENT

In the New Testament Jesus becomes the point of focus Heb 1:1-3. Jesus is the definitive point of salvation history Acts 4:12. We have twenty seven different writings that differently express the view of Jesus Christ.

These documents are often either grouped in four or three divisions/categories. We will follow a three fold division.

1. Historical writings. These consists of the four canonical gospels, i.e., Mathew, Mark, Luke and John and the Acts of the apostles. We classify the gospels as historical because, in a several term they are about the “history” of Jesus while the Acts are about the “history” of the early church.

Mark is the earliest gospel to be written (ca 68-70). Mathew and Luke relied on Mark as a primary source. Hence these gospels share similar characteristics like the same world view, language and the framework. In these gospels for example Jesus ministry is a journey that begins in Galilee and ends in Jerusalem. These three gospels are known as the synoptic gospels. They can be general be viewed together in a comparable way.

However it must not be forgotten that there are distinctive emphasizes in each gospel. Mark, for example, emphasizes on the need for the Christians to expect suffering. It can rightly to called good news in hard times. The Christians were facing persecution (Mk 13:9). The Christians are urged to always keep watch.

Mathew is the most favoured gospel by the Church. It is the only gospel that explicitly mentions the word Church. The gospel greatly emphasizes the community life (Mt. 18).

Luke emphasizes the universality of the Jesus' message in a remarkable way. Jesus is descendant of Adam, the first human parent (Lk 3:38 ; cf Mt1:1).

The Acts of the Apostles is a continuation of Luke's gospel (1 $^{1-5}$). It is the second volume and the gospel is the first. The gospel proclaims salvation to all while act points to the realization of this reality. It is a fulfillment of the proclamation.

John is considered as a supplement gospel. It elaborates on issues concerning Jesus in a deeper level. It is, therefore, designated as a highly theological gospel.

2. **Didactical Writings**

Didactical writings are mainly letters or epistles. The letters are twofold; the ones that are addressed to particular communities or persons. This type of letters composes the Pauline letters. The other grouping is the General or Apostolic letters. The general letters possess a universal character, that is to say, they were not directed to specific church community. Therefore, they are rightly called Catholic Epistles.

The Pauline letters are 13. These letters include: Romans, 1 Corinthians, 2 Corinthians, Galatians, Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, 1 Thessalonians, 2 Thessalonians, 1 Timothy, 2 Timothy, Titus and Philemon.

Paul tends to model his letters on the ancient form of Greek letter writing. Therefore, a reading of Paul's letters exhibits a particular format or pattern. The Pauline format is threefold.

1. We have an introduction. The introduction has two part

    a) Salutation or greetings. Here Paul mentions the sender(s) and the recipients

    b) Thanksgiving. Paul commends the Christian community for the good they have done.

In our reading of the letter to 1 Thessalonians (the first Christian document ever written) 1 Thess 1 [1] is a greeting.

Who do we see as the senders of this letter?

Paul, Timothy and Silas are listed as the senders. These three can be understood as the authors of this letter.

Paul greets the community with a message of Grace and Peace. This is a popular pauline greeting formulation. What does Paul mean with these two words.

Grace (*charis*) is that gift from God that is underserved, it is a free favour which ultimately leads to salvation.

Peace (*Shalom*) is the most talked about aspect. Generally people see peace as the absence of war. The biblical peace runs much deeper. It denotes a totality or wholeness of relationship. It is an integrity of one's health, one's relationship with neighbour and God.

After greetings Paul moves to the thanksgiving. 1 Thess 1 2-10 is a thanksgiving.

What does Paul thank this community for?

Paul thanks them for three virtues (faith, love and hope).

Faith –it is a commitment to Christ and all that he stands for. Paul greatly emphases the aspect of faith throughout his letters. It is the greatest gift of God to humanity. It is brought about by God's saving power (Rom 3:24-26). Faith is what leads us ultimately to our salvation.

It is humanity's profound response of God's initiative recognized in his word and saving interventions.

This response means an intelligent adherence. St. Augustine rightly puts it that faith must seek understanding. Biblically faith implies trust and truth. It is an absolute trust in the living and true God, a dependence exclusively on him and loving obedience. (Rom 15, 6;17, 2 Cor 104, 1 Thes 1:6, 2 Thes 18).

Christian faith has three dimensions. **Belief conviction:** It is a conviction in certain truths or doctrines. We, for example, believe that Christ will come again at the end of time.

Trusting Relationship: The Kingdom of God is a calling to a relationship of unbounded trust in the faithfulness of God and in the power of God's saving grace expressed through prayer. In the Old Testament there are people trusting in the promises of God. (Mk 11:22-23).

Life of Love or doing: Life of loving calls for engagement in the world. It is not for the sake of individual but for the good of humanity. Living faith is found in doing (James 2:14-18, 24,26). Faith is active through love and produces the delighted trusts of charity (Rom 8:14, 1Cor. 6:9-11, Gal. 5:25, 6:8). Jesus thus notes that it is not those who call me Lord Lord but those who do my will that will be saved. A good tree ends up being known by its fruits. As the people of God our Gospel ought to be seen in the life we live. It is no longer I who lives but Christ who lives in me. What distinguished the early Christians from the rest was in the manner they lived.

Love – this is a service we offer to others. It is best translated as charity.

Hope –it is a confidence that the Lord will come. Hope helps us to endure the trials of this present life.

The thanksgiving can provide clues to what Paul will discuss in the body of the letter.

2. **Body**

Here Paul discusses the problems that were troubling particular communities. Paul's letters are situational or occassional writings. They rose out of particular situations affecting communities Paul had founded. These letters were answers to question Paul was being asked or issues that he over heared. 1 Thes 2^{1}-5^{11} is an example of the body of the letter. Some of the issues discussed include love as a characteristic of Christian life. It is meant to be shown for each other and even those outside 1 Thes 4^{9-10}. The other issue regards sexual morality. Paul insists that the only appropriate place for sexual activity was in marriage. Sexual issues are predominantly addressed in the letters of Paul. In his letter to the Corinthians, Paul tells the Christians at Corinth that they cannot go and buy sex from the Prostitutes in

the Seaport (1 Cor 6 $^{12-20}$). Christians should be opposed to the homosexual behaviour since it is a perversion of God's natural order (Rom 1 $^{26-27}$).

Knowing the situation Paul is writing from is key to understanding his writings. We must also make distinction between what is said that was time bound, that is, what was meant for that particular time and what he recommends for all the time. The wearing of veil for example or women speaking in church assemblies was for only a particular time.

3. **Conclusion**

Paul ends his letters with a benediction, i.e., a short of blessing 1 Thess 5 12-26.

The major exception to this format is the letter to the Galatians. Paul moves straight from the greetings to the body. It has no thanksgiving. This tells us the kind of community it was.

One may ask whether Paul wrote all these letters. I want to broaden the question further whether these are the only letters Paul wrote.

Today we know Paul wrote more letters that we no longer have. Paul most likely wrote four letters for instance to the community in Corinth. We today have only two.

The 13 letters attributed to Paul are classified in three categories.

1. Genuinely Paul or authentically Paul. These are letters that no one doubts Paul's authorship. They are seven in total. These include: Roman, 1 & 2 Corinthian, 1 Thessalonians, Galatians, Philippians and Philemon.

2. Doubtfully Paul. In these letters questions are raised whether Paul wrote them or not. The arguments are generally based on language and content to some extend. These letters are: Ephesians, Colossians, 2 Thessalonians. The first two are very similar in content.

3. Not Paul: these letters were certainly not written by Paul. The situations discussed in the letters reflect a period long after Paul had died. These letters are 1 & 2 Timothy and Titus.

These letters give Christianity both its foundation and character. They are the earliest ever written Christian documents and make about a third of the New Testament.

Bible as a Piece of Literature

The Bible has been described as the greatest piece of literature ever written. The question that this statement evokes in the reader's mind is what do you mean by labeling the Bible as literature?

The Bible is a text shaped by use of language. We, for example, list a number of literary forms as: myths, legends, songs, proverbs, sermons, letters etc. These are examples of general forms of literary expression. We can talk of two classifications of these forms, i.e., poetry and prose.

The focus of this section will be on the Old Testament. The Old Testament will be treated as represent text for the whole Bible.

The Literary Genres of the Bible

The biblical genre is so diverse. We find for example songs, laws, letters. Proverbs, sermons etc in the Bible. Despite of the diversity the literature can be grouped into two, i.e., poetry and prose. Both poetry and prose co-exist side by side in the Bible. Virtually half of the Bible is a poetic text. We can for example mention the Psalms, Lamentations, the Song of Songs, book of Proverbs etc. the question is the distinction between the two.

i) Poetry

There are certain characteristics that distinguish poetry from prose. The most significant characteristic of the Hebrew poetry is the use of parallelism. The word parallelism reminds us of our Mathematics class where we learnt about parallel lines. The concept revolves around two items. When we apply it to language we are talking about a repetition.

In Hebrew poetry we identify four kinds of repetitions/parallelisms.

i) Repetitive (synonyms) parallelism

ii) Adversative (antithetical) parallelism

iii) Complementary (synthetic) parallelism

iv) Climatic (ontological) parallelism

Synonymous parallelism is formed when two clauses expression the same idea but using different words. The second verse or line repeats the thoughts of the first while using different terminologies. We have here example like Ps 24:1-6 or Lk 12: 22-23.

In antithetical parallelism the second line says the opposite of the first. The contrast is effected by placing positive and negative expressions side by side. We see this for instance in Ps 37:16-17 or Mt 7: 17-18.

Synthetic parallelism is a situation where the second verse supplements the first. The second verse flows as a continuing logical extension of the thought of the first verse for example Ps 51:14-15 or Mt 23: 6-7. Ontological – the second line goes beyond the first in climactic manner. This is generally reached through repeating of a word or several words from the first. The case in point is for instance in Ps 29:1 or Mt 10:40.

Hebrew poetry also employs the use of images. These images bear witness to a personification of natural elements. We have examples of streams clapping their hands and mountains that rejoice Ps 98:8. We also read about the personification of the son in Ps 19 6-7.

It also uses metaphors and similes. These are both figures of comparison that bear witness to the energetic imagination of the poets of Ancient Israel (Ps 23:117; Ps 1:3-4 etc). Among other things, Hebrew poetry is full of rhyme and rhythm. This aspect is unfortunately lost in the translations.

Poetry in the Old Testament can be categorized either as profane or religious.

Profane Poetry

At first sight most student are taken a batch by the mention of something profane in the Bible. Remember recently in China there are attempts to index the Bible on the ground of sexual overtones. When we talk about profane we mean literature that had their original setting in secular surroundings. Most readers will have no problem singling out the Song of Songs.

However, it must be noted that an absolute distinction between profane and religious poetry remains an impossible task. Most profane literature have gained religious overtones, for example, the nationalistic song of Deborah (Jud 5).

We can point out some examples of profane poetry.

The so called Song of the Well (Num 21:17-18).

The poet summons the well to provide water a new. This was a common practice in ancient world when a well dried up, feasts were held to stimulate a restoration of the water flow.

The Song of Revenge (Gen 4 23-24).

Lamech prides himself of his unconstrained bloodlust. This is completely strange among the Israelites.

Mockery songs: these were either political or religious. They were sang upon the realization of victory (Judy 527-30). The religious mocking songs focused generally on the importance of idols (Jer 10:30-5).

Hebrew profane poetry also includes proverb, a sort of adage or short saying (Ez. 18:2 or Jer 31 :29).

We may also include the riddle in this grouping (Judg 14: 12-18). This riddle read like the story of Lwanda Magere (the famous Luo Hero).

In sum, we may conclude that the Old Testament both preserved and transmitted profane poetry.

Religious Poetry

Religious poetry is of greater significance than the profane poetry in the Old Testament. The latter is largely dependent on the former.

A distinction can be made in the context of religious poetry in terms of proverbs and songs. Proverbs are generally short expressions of ethical or religious character.

A proverb can be of different nature, i.e. priestly, wisdom, and prophetic in nature. Priestly proverbs are responses given by priests to requests or consultations cf. 1 Sam 23: 9-12; Haggai 2 12-14, Ps 24 3-5.

Prophetic proverbs are related to priestly one. It is different to draw a distinction between the two. It can be assumed that while the priestly instruction was associated with cultic occasions (Heb 2:11-13) the prophetic word had more to do with political matters (1 Kgs 22:5 ff.; Jer. 28; Micah 3:11). The prophets frequently make us of the formula. Thus say Yhwh or the words of Yhwh.

Wisdom sayings were aimed at a positive participation in social life and a judicious organization of individual existence. These sayings are normally fixed and pointed to the content to provide their teachings with a degree of authority and influence. It also made them easy to remember (Qoh 12:11).

Original the proverb consisted of a verse (Prov. 26: 7-9, 11).

Proverbs are a kin to riddles. The ability to solve a proverb and riddle was seen as an elevated form of wisdom.

Proverbs, however, developed from short forms to longer forms of teaching through additions gained in experiential testimonies (Prov. 7:6 ff; 24:30-34).

Religious song occurs frequently in the Old Testament. Music was part and parcel of an Israelite's life. However, we can distinguish the following backgrounds for songs; prophetic preaching, cultic circles and lives of individuals.

We can generally identify several types of songs that include hymns of praise, thanksgiving songs, lament songs, penitential and didactic songs. Examples of these are spread all over the Old Testament.

The most frequently represented of these songs are those of praise. These songs land the magnificence and majesty of Yhwh. The essential elements in the songs include the call to praise God and the reason why this praise should be done (Ps. 117; Ex 15:21). The call to praise can consist of a single verse (Ps 98:1) or several verses (Ps 118:1-4; 135:1-3) and is sometimes repeated in the course of the Psalm (Ps 98:4-8).

The motivation behind the appeal to praise the wonderful deeds of God is often introduced by the conjunction "for (Ps 98:1-9). Sometimes a participated clause may be used (Ps 9:36 and 147).

Thanksgiving songs: these can be individual or communal. Individual songs of thanksgiving relate to the situation of need from which an individual has been saved (1 Sam 2:1-10). It was often possible to combine thanksgiving and praise songs like in cases of Ps. 116 or Jonah 2.

Lament songs – these too can be individual or collective. These songs were recited at moments of great need and during penitential feasts and were accompanied as a rule by periods of fasting (Ps 44, 74, 79, 80, and Joel 2:15-17). The songs served as prayers for the restoration of God's salvific care.

Lament songs exhibit a particular structure that consists of these elements; invocation, lament, confession of trust in God, prayer of entreaty and vow of praise. However the most striking feature of most lament song is the abrupt change of mood. This occurs when there is a sudden shift from lament to thanksgiving (Ps. 6:9-11; 22 23-32; 31:20 ff).

Penitential songs these represent a profound and heartfelt expression of shame and repentance for past sins (Ps 51, Jer 3:23-25 and 14:7-9).

Didactic poems – these songs represent utterances of individual expressed in poetic form. These songs provide the books of Psalms as a whole with its abiding value, offering a point of identification to those who read them in moment of need, struggle and gratitude up to the present day.

Prose

Prose material in the Old Testament offer varied range of form. We can, however, talk of three classifications: legal documents, official records and narrative material.

Legal Material

Most people define the bible as the book of dos and don'ts. They are indirectly referring to the legal materials. The Torah consists of substantial of the legal materials.

Central to the law is the Decalogue. We have two versions of the Decalogue in the Old Testament (Ex 20:1-17 and Deut 5:6-22). The other laws derive their authority from these laws. We read in the Bible that these words were directly communicated by God to Moses. The Biblical writers attaches to the Decalogue.

The oldest forms of the law are present in the "book of the covenant". (Ex 21-23). These laws are of diverse formulation and content.

Generally a distinction is made between two forms: casuistic and apodictic formulations.

Casuistic legal formulations are conditional, i.e., they are dependent on a particular situation. They are introduced by phrases like when, if etc.

Apodictic formulations are prohibitive by nature. (Lev 20:2, Deut 27: 15-26, Ex 22:18). These laws reflect Israel's ancient religious legislation which had its basis in the word of Yhwh.

There laws for most part had to do with the totality of a person's religious and ethical life (Lev 19: 3-4, 11-12 and Lev 19: 13-18).

Jesus summarized the laws into one command of love (15:12; Lev19:18).

Official Records

Official records are mainly lists. These are lists of returnees Babylonian exile (Ezra 2 & Nehemiah 7), list of the builders of the walls of Jerusalem (Nehemiah 3), genealogies (Gen 10) etc.

Questions have been asked regarding the significance of such lists. However, it must be noted that the lists of names in particular with frequent reference to the *op horic* (containing a divine element)

personal names, are of extraordinary religious – historical significance, even though they may not be among the most loved segments of the Old Testament.

Other forms of official records are present in annals (2 Sam 8:1-14; 1 Kgs 9:10-28); epistolary literature (Jer 29 & Ezra 4-5) and court order (Ezra 1:2-4).

Narrative Material

Narrative is the important of the prose materials.

Narratives exhibit characteristics of a spoken narration, rather than a purely literary composition. They, for instance, frequently make use of exclamations like “see”, “behold”. This element is meant to call the reader to attention. It is an invitation to the reader to identify with the story.

Another characteristics of the Hebrew narrative is its use of repetition as a means to increase tension. You find in the narrative the main character recounting his experiences (Gen 24; the narrative of the wedding of Rebekah and Isaac). The execution of the already given command tends to be reported in the same words as the command itself (2 Sam 14:24).

A further characteristic of the narrative is that the intention or the purpose of a narrative is often disclosed only in its conclusion. When for example you are dealing with the account of the first fall, it is Gen 3:24 that ends by stating that humans were driven from the garden of Eden and that Cherubs were stationed to prevent them from gaining access to the tree of life; the paradise narrative is thus intended to explain how humans had lost their right of access to the tree of life. Gen 11:9 explains the intention of the narrative of the Tower of Babel: the dispersion of humankind over all the earth.

The actual objective of a narrative can also be stated directly in its opening verses (Gen 22:1).

Old Testament narrative also frequently makes use of word-play which is lost in translation. We read that man was made from clay (*Adam* and *Adamah*), a woman was formed from man (*Issah* and *Ish*), Sara laughed and she gave birth to laughter (Isaac) etc.

The designation narrative is itself a complex term. It contains within itself a variety of other literary forms. We have other forms like; myths which tend to enjoy only a limited place in the Old Testament (Gen 6:1-4). We also have in the Old Testament fold narratives in form of legends related to sanctuaries and prophets together with heroic, nature and tribal sages (Gen 18-19). Judg 13-16 the Samson story.

We find another form of narrative which is found in the biographies and autobiographies. We have examples of biography (Jer. 26-45). Autobiographies include the memoirs of Ezra (Ezra 7 ff) and Nehemiah (Neh 1-2, 4-7).

This part explores the values that we find within the Bible. The section further explores aspects of human calling to stewardship. It leads us on what the Bible says about things like work, justice, freedom, love, leadership etc.